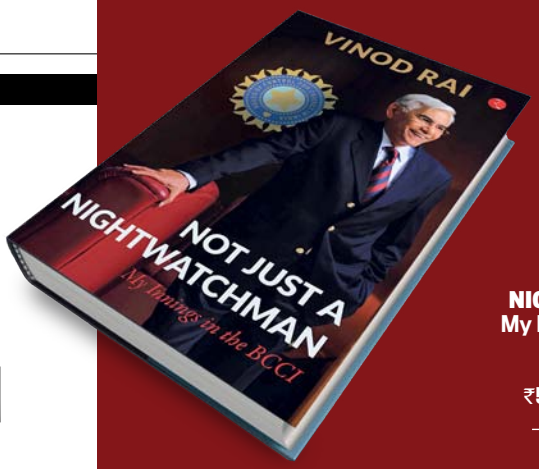
BOOKS

WRITING ON THE BOARD

Vinod Rai's memoir of the 33 months he spent trying to fix the BCCI is detailed but also diplomatic



NOT JUST A NIGHTWATCHMAN
My Innings in the BCCI
by Vinod Rai
RUPA
₹**595; 240** pages

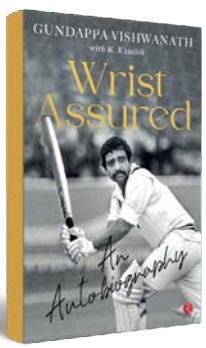
Vinod Rai starts on the front foot. In his introduction, he writes, "I hope people will realise that cricket, which is known to be a gentleman's game, needs to be administered by gentlemen, who do their bit with sincerity, objectivity and transparency. After having done their bit, they should move on with grace and dignity, giving space to a new breed of administrators who think like the new breed of cricketers." This suggests unfettered aggression *a la* Virender Sehwag over the 200-odd pages of the book, but his 'insider's view' of how the BCCI functions doesn't quite live up to the early promise.

Rai, former Comptroller and Auditor General of India, with a penchant for penning down his experiences in high office for posterity (his earlier book, *Not Just an Accountant*, dealt with controversies such as the 2G

EVERY INCH A HERO

To again connect with all that is good and noble in cricket, read **Gundappa Vishwanath's** recently released autobiography

WRIST ASSURED
by Gundappa Vishwanath & R. Kaushik
RUPA
₹**595; 280** pages



The only time I ran onto the cricket field during a match (I was 12), my hero Gundappa Vishwanath had reached a 50. I shook hands with him. You shouldn't meet your heroes or you will be disappointed, I was told later. But I didn't have to readjust my sights at all. You came for the square cut, but stayed for the charm, a charm that is also the strength of his autobiography, co-authored with journalist R. Kaushik.

There was a vulnerability about Vishwanath's batting that is the companion of those who operate on the edge of the possible. It is an attractive quality in a performing artist, from tight-rope walkers to classical singers. If Sunil Gavaskar was the Apollo of Indian cricket, all intellect and technique, Vishwanath was the Dionysus, all ecstasy and unexpectedness.

It is nearly 40 years since he retired, yet Vishwanath remains the exemplar of wristy Indian batsmanship, and connects us with all that is good and noble in the game. Skipper Vishwanath once recalled Bob Taylor to the crease when he knew the batsman wasn't out. He lost the Test but gained something bigger. He is probably the most loved cricketer of my time—a love that went beyond respect or admiration, although it contained both.

I would have been disappointed if his autobiography had spilled the beans on the disastrous 1974 tour of England, or the many series that had as much intrigue and conspiracy as runs and wickets. That is not Vishwanath's way; I was not disappointed.

There is instead a remarkable honesty—he writes, for instance, of how he might have been leg before early on in the match against Mumbai that ended the latter's run of 15 Ranji triumphs in a row (he went on to make 162). The book's best parts are the famous Vishwanath anecdotes—funny, self-deprecating, delivered with a twinkle in the eye. Like the time he addressed Richie Benaud as 'Bednau' because the commentator had called him 'Vishnawath', or the private vacation he had with Tiger Pataudi.

Vishwanath, Gavaskar and the Spinning Foursome (Bishan Bedi, Erapalli Prasanna, Bhagwat Chandrasekhar and Srinivas Venkatraghavan) placed India on the doorstep to greatness. India never